Agent Empathy Canvas

Like a UX empathy canvas, but the persona is an agent working on a person's behalf. Fill it in to find out which skills to write and which MCPs to build.

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jasonrutterford-cyber.github.io
jasonrutterford-cyber.github.io/writing/we-used-to-design-for-humans/

Agent
What is it called, and where does it run?

Acts on behalf of
Which person or role? One actor per canvas.

Task or job story
When [situation], I want the agent to [do], so that [outcome].

Trigger
What starts it? A request, an event, a schedule?

Purpose
What is the agent here to achieve for the person? What does "done well" look like?

Becomes skills
what the agent must know how to do: its instructions

Do
What actions does it take or complete?

Process
What does it analyse, calculate or decide?

Inform
Who does it tell, and what? Updates, records.

Explain
What must it justify: reasoning, confidence, options?

Skills to write
One per distinct capability: name — what it covers.

Boundaries
What stays with the human? When must it ask, escalate or stop? What must it never do?

Becomes MCPs
what the agent reads, finds and writes to: its data, tools and destinations

Consume
What data, documents and systems does it always read?

Discover
What must it find out, look up or check for this case before acting?

Deliver + skills
What does it produce, in what format, and where does it land?

MCPs to build
One per system: name — what it exposes (read / write).

Success measures
How we know it does the job well: outcome, quality, time and trust.

Purpose and Boundaries frame the agent · Needs that become skills · Needs that become MCPs · Deliver: outputs that need both

Agent Empathy Canvas · free to use, change and pass on · jasonrutterford-cyber.github.io/tools/agent-empathy-canvas/

Agent Empathy Canvas — worked example

Travel planning: an AI assistant given travel skills, working for a consultant who visits client sites. A made-up example; no real company.

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Agent
What is it called, and where does it run?

- Your AI assistant (Claude, Copilot or ChatGPT), given travel skills

Acts on behalf of
Which person or role? One actor per canvas.

- Consultant who travels to client sites

Task or job story
When [situation], I want the agent to [do], so that [outcome].

- When a client visit is confirmed, I want the agent to plan and book my travel within policy, so that I arrive prepared without spending an hour on booking sites.

Trigger
What starts it? A request, an event, a schedule?

- Client visit confirmed in the calendar

Purpose
What is the agent here to achieve for the person? What does "done well" look like?

- Get the consultant to the client on time, within policy, with no admin
- Done well = itinerary ready within an hour of confirmation; the consultant only approves

Becomes skills
what the agent must know how to do: its instructions

Do
What actions does it take or complete?

- Shortlist flights, trains and hotels
- Hold the chosen options
- Book once approved
- Add each leg to the calendar

Process
What does it analyse, calculate or decide?

- Check every option against travel policy
- Work back from the meeting time to departure
- Compare cost, journey time and loyalty
- Spot clashes with other meetings

Inform
Who does it tell, and what? Updates, records.

- Consultant: shortlist, then booking confirmation
- Manager: any out-of-policy request
- Client host: expected arrival time

Explain
What must it justify: reasoning, confidence, options?

- Why this option is recommended
- What's out of policy and by how much
- How confident it is that connections work

Skills to write
One per distinct capability: name — what it covers.

- trip-planning — work back from the meeting to build the trip
- policy-checking — apply travel policy and flag exceptions
- option-recommendation — compare options and explain the pick
- itinerary-templates — structure and quality bar for itinerary and arrival note
- traveller-updates — who to tell what, and when

Boundaries
What stays with the human? When must it ask, escalate or stop? What must it never do?

- Never books anything without the consultant's approval
- Never goes over policy without manager sign-off
- Asks when two options are close on cost and time
- Stops and escalates if the visit is under 48 hours away and fares jump

Becomes MCPs
what the agent reads, finds and writes to: its data, tools and destinations

Consume
What data, documents and systems does it always read?

- Travel policy (policy library)
- Consultant's calendar
- Traveller profile and preferences
- Approved suppliers list

Discover
What must it find out, look up or check for this case before acting?

- Client site address and nearest airport or station
- Entry or visa rules for the destination
- Local events pushing prices up

Deliver + skills
What does it produce, in what format, and where does it land?

- Itinerary (PDF) → consultant's inbox
- Calendar entry per leg → consultant's calendar
- Booking record → expense system
- Arrival note (email) → client host

MCPs to build
One per system: name — what it exposes (read / write).

- calendar — read meetings; write travel holds
- travel-booking — search, hold and book
- policy-library — read travel policy
- expense-system — write booking records
- email — send itinerary and arrival note

Success measures
How we know it does the job well: outcome, quality, time and trust.

- Trips booked within policy (target 98%)
- Consultant time per trip (target under 5 minutes)
- Itinerary ready within an hour of confirmation
- How often the consultant overrides the pick (trust)

Purpose and Boundaries frame the agent · Needs that become skills · Needs that become MCPs · Deliver: outputs that need both

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How to run the canvas

An hour with the people who do the work today. The person the agent serves stays in the room.

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Seven steps

1. **Start with the person, not the agent.** Name who it works for and what they are trying to get done. If you can’t say what they get out of it, stop here.
2. **Write the job story.** When [situation], I want the agent to [do], so that [outcome]. One actor, one outcome, one canvas.
3. **Frame it: purpose and boundaries.** What “done well” looks like, and what stays with a human. Leaders read Boundaries first, so draw them deliberately.
4. **Fill the six middle blocks with the people who do the work today.** Do, Process, Inform, Explain become skills. Consume, Discover, Deliver become MCPs. Discover is not the same as Consume: most missing connections hide in what the agent has to go and find out for each case.
5. **Name what it delivers.** “It helps with travel” can’t be built. “An itinerary as a PDF in the inbox, a calendar entry per leg, a booking record in the expense system” can. If you can’t name the output, the outcome isn’t clear yet.
6. **Turn each skill into a job story** your team can write, build and test (right). If the process owner can’t read and sign off a skill, it’s too vague or too technical.
7. **Agree the success measures** before anything is built: outcome, quality, time and trust. If the Explain box is empty, people won’t trust the agent.

You don’t need to build an agent. Claude, Copilot and ChatGPT already are the agents. What they lack is your context: the skills that say how to do the job, and the connections (MCPs) that reach your data and deliver to the right place. The canvas finds both, starting from the person. Full write-up and worked example: jasonrutterford-cyber.github.io/writing/we-used-to-design-for-humans/

Skills = how to do the job | MCPs = what it can reach | Deliverables = what lands where

From canvas to a job story

Skill: policy-checking

When	the agent shortlists travel for a confirmed client visit,
it needs to	check every option against the travel policy and explain anything that falls outside it,
so that	the consultant only sees trips they can book without chasing approval.
Sub-stories	When a hotel is over the nightly limit, say by how much. When nothing is in policy, ask the manager to approve the cheapest option. Never book it unapproved.
Done when	98% of trips are booked in policy, and every exception shows the reason and the cost difference.

Where each part comes from: Trigger and Process give you “When”. Do and Explain give you “it needs to”. Purpose gives you “so that”. Boundaries become the rules. Success measures become “done when”. That’s a requirement a business owner can read and sign off, and a team can turn into a skill and test.